

Creation, conservation, and providence

However we define the exact extent of divine power, classical theists have always agreed that God's power is great enough to confer on him the capacity to create and providentially superintend the existence of everything distinct from God. How are we to understand these characteristics of God as creator and providential superintender? Some theists suppose that God's creating activity consists merely of rearranging already existing entities. For example, Plato's divine Demiurge engages in the act of creation by imparting specific sorts of order on a pre-existing reality. Yet most theists hold that God creates and fashions the world out of no pre-existing materials at all. Creation of this sort is typically designated by the phrase "creation *ex nihilo*." Strictly speaking, theists have taken the doctrine of divine creation *ex nihilo* to entail that the universe came into existence at some time in the finite past. And such a view corresponds to the best cosmological theories that scientists currently accept. But this has not always been the case. At numerous times throughout scientific and philosophical history it has seemed that the best evidence available pointed to a universe that is infinitely old. Would a beginningless universe imply that God is not its creator?

Not necessarily. In addition to holding that God is the originating cause of the universe, theists have also traditionally held that God must sustain

the universe in existence from moment to moment. Descartes, for example, gave a striking argument for this claim, arguing that since no instant of the universe contains within itself anything which would explain or guarantee its existence at the next moment of time, something else must guarantee this. And that thing, Descartes argued, is God. This form of divine activity, commonly called divine conservation (springing from the Latin “*conservare*” which means “to maintain or preserve”), implies that, even if the universe were beginningless, God would be its creator in the sense that his existence is metaphysically or explanatorily prior to the existence of the universe. This is so because God’s existence and causal activity is required to sustain the universe in existence from moment to moment.

In addition to creating and conserving, most classical theists have held that God is also involved in the occurrence of each and every event, or the exercise of every causal power by creatures. Thus, when the cue ball strikes the eight-ball, God is in some sense involved in bringing it about that the collision causes the eight-ball to move. This exercise of divine power, called divine concurrence, supposes that God is intimately involved not only in preserving the world in existence, but in the activity of created things as well. Why do theists hypothesize the reality of divine concurrence? Some do so because they take it to be revealed in scriptural texts. Christian thinkers in the Middle Ages commonly cited St. Paul’s claim that “In God we live, and move, and have our being” as evidence for such divine activity. As they saw it, “having our being” refers to creation, “living” refers to conservation, and “moving” refers to God’s concurrence.

There are, in addition, three important philosophical motivations for supposing that God concurs with creaturely action in this way. First, some theists, such as Thomas Aquinas, contend that it is through divine concurrence that God is able to know what creatures will do when they act. Since God makes a causal contribution to the creature’s act, God can know the outcome by knowing his own action. Second, others have argued that divine concurrence is necessary, since without it creatures would have, and would be able to exercise, causal powers in a way that is completely independent of divine control. Such abilities, it is argued, undermine God’s ability to providentially superintend every event that happens in creation. Finally, some have argued that every instance of causation involves one substance causing some new thing to come into existence (either another thing or some property in an already existing thing). However, since God is the only

true source or cause of being, no created thing could be a true cause all by itself. Thus God must be involved in every causal event in nature.

Such motivations raise some serious difficulties, however. Consider the first. If God is able to know what a creature would or will do simply by knowing God's own causal contribution to the creature's action, it follows that God's contribution is sufficient for the creaturely action to occur. But if God's concurring contribution is sufficient in this way, then the creature cannot have any genuine control over its action since what God does determines what the creature will do. Such an account is especially worrisome when we consider free creaturely action. If the actions of creatures are determined by a causal contribution by God, it is hard to see how these actions can count as genuinely free. What is more, such an account makes it acutely difficult to explain the reality of evil. If God can prevent creatures from freely choosing evil by simply causing them to refrain from it, why would God not do so?

The second motivation leads to a different problem. If theists who accept concurrence do so because they are reluctant to give creatures any sort of independent causal powers, they will have to provide an account of how the causal contributions of God and creatures collaborate to produce causal effects. Perhaps God and creatures cooperate in causing events in the way that two horses pulling a wagon do. In that case, each horse contributes its causal powers so that they together produce the motion. If this were the model for divine concurrence, some important questions must be answered. For example, is the causal contribution of each agent necessary for the effect to obtain, or is one or the other of the causal contributions sufficient on its own? If the first, then it appears that God is merely a partial cause, and that the creature is providing some real causal contribution quite independently of any causal contribution on God's part. That might seem unproblematic, until we remember that we were motivated to adopt the notion of divine concurrence as a way of denying that creatures make independent causal contributions to events obtaining in the world. If, on the other hand, one of the concurring causes would be sufficient on its own, that contributing cause would have to be God. After all, the whole point of introducing concurrence was that creaturely causal contributions could not alone suffice for the effects. Yet if God's causal contribution were sufficient, then it is hard to see how the creature's contribution helps bring about the effect at all. The creature would be like a little child standing behind a car

and pushing on the bumper as the car accelerates forward. In that case, the child might think she caused the car to move, even though she didn't.

The third motivation is problematic for similar reasons. It holds that objects or events that come to exist through some sort of creaturely causal activity get their existence or being directly from God. However, if God causes the existence of the effects of creaturely action in this way, it appears that it is God, and not the creature, who brings these things about. As a result, the creature once again seems to play no real role in causation after all.

Because of these difficulties, some theists have adopted an even more radical account of divine action in the world. If it is important that God has a role in bringing about effects in the world, and yet all models of concurrence fail, it must be the case that God is the sole cause of all effects that come to pass. This view, known as occasionalism, has been most famously defended by the seventeenth-century French philosopher Nicholas Malebranche. According to the occasionalist, while it might appear to us that the collision of the cue-ball and the eight-ball causes the eight-ball to move, the collision instead provides merely an occasion on which God alone will cause the eight-ball to move as it does. On this view, the laws of nature are not descriptions of the causal powers had by created things, but rather descriptions of how God has committed himself to act when certain events occur in the world.

In light of the problems generated by the notion of divine concurrence, occasionalism may seem to be an attractive alternative. Note, however, that it actually faces some of the same difficulties that divine concurrence does. Two difficulties are especially noteworthy. First, if occasionalism is true, it seems that genuine free action by creatures is ruled out. When a creature makes a free choice or forms a free act of will, the creature must be, in some crucial way, the root and cause of the action. If occasionalism is true, however, there appears to be no way for the creature to be such a cause. Second, if occasionalism is true, every event in the universe is brought about directly by God. If this is right, however, one would expect the world to contain no evil. Of course, all varieties of theism must confront the problem of evil. But most theists are insistent, as we will see in chapter 6, that God does not cause evil but rather merely (justifiably) permits it. Seeing God as merely permitting evil provides a moral buffer that would be unavailable if God were the full and direct cause of evil as is the case with

occasionalism. This view thus makes God “the author of sin,” a position that has been almost universally rejected by theists.

We were led to consider the possible truth of occasionalism because, first, it seemed that the greatest possible being would have some sort of direct involvement with the occurrence of every event in nature in a way that transcended mere conservation, and second, because the model of involvement through concurrence faced potent objections. Perhaps these assumptions are mistaken. Perhaps, that is, the greatest possible being need only be regularly causally connected to the world as its creator and sustainer. This view is commonly known as deism. How does this view fare?

To answer this question we must go back and consider the reasons why theists think that God’s causal involvement in creation must go beyond creation and conservation alone. The first reason was that such additional causal involvement would be needed for God to have knowledge of how creatures would or will act and, as a result, would be needed for God to exercise providential control. As we have seen, and will see in greater detail in chapter 2, this claim is highly contentious. There are other models of divine knowledge and providence which do not involve divine concurrence at all. The second and third reasons involved the claim that, absent concurrence, creatures would be objectionably causally independent, either because they could act independently of God, or could produce being (the being of objects or events as the effects of their actions). However, these objections are not especially forceful. First, as we saw earlier in our discussion of divine power, if some creatures have free choice, it seems that their actions must indeed have a very strong sort of causal independence in any case. Second, while some accounts of causation hypothesize that causes bring about new instances of being in their effects, this view is highly controversial.